

Have you ever felt that everything is happening too early for you?

Not really. I take things as they come. I always wanted to be a footballer, and I did nothing except play the game I love. So, whenever I got the opportunity to play football, I played – whether it was for the club or the national team, I didn't think much.

Having been crowned world champions in 2010, Spain could not progress even to the semifinals in the following three editions. Will that change this year?

It's impossible to predict, especially in a World Cup. But what we know is that we are a group of fascinating players who want to give our all in the field to earn national glory. We played a near-perfect qualification round (five wins and a draw) and

debutant Cape Verde should not be a concern...

You can never say so. Each team in the final 48 deserves respect. They are there because they have earned it. And how can one forget that the Saudis had beaten Argentina in Qatar, in their first match? Facing Uruguay will always be a tough ask. They have a rich football history and are one of the strong contenders.

Spain is considered to be one of the favourites to win the Cup. Your thoughts?

I do not believe in these tags. Football is played on the field, not on paper. We were not considered favourites to win the last Euro. But we won it. Now people are saying we are contenders for the World Cup. However, the tag does not help you

we are looking forward to those matches only. It's always preferred to look at things in your hand. Let us qualify for the knockouts first. We shall be thinking about the opponents only then. We always take it match by match.

If you were to pick favourites for this World Cup?

There are quite a few, namely Argentina, France, Portugal, England and a few other teams as well. The World Cup never ceases to surprise you. So, we should never count any team out before the tournament.

You are already compared with Lionel Messi. Does it add pressure?

I have always said that I do not want to be the next Messi. I want to be myself.

« I do not want to be the next Messi; I want to be myself »

LAMINE YAMAL

qualified directly. We did not lose a match in the last two years or so. These say that we have been really consistent. We want to do the same in the forthcoming World Cup.

In Group H, it seems on paper that you have only Uruguay as a major contender to finish the campaign on top. Saudi Arabia and the

play better or score more goals. We, the footballers, have to do it during the match.

After the group stages, there will be tougher opponents. How do you look at it?

Well, I am not at all thinking about the knockouts at this moment. We have three matches in the group, and

I do respect Messi for what he has achieved as a footballer. He is a phenomenon! But I really do not want to be the next Messi or, for that matter, Cristiano Ronaldo, Kylian Mbappe or Neymar Jr. I shall be happy if I can reach a level where people can name me after those legends rather than comparing to them.



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